

Artificial intelligence is essentially the nuclear bomb of the digital age. AI can cause devastating harms (and is already) and thus must be regulated as a potential weapon. But unlike the nuclear bomb, its primary harms are not physical but psychosocial and economic. We don't just need to be concerned with what AI *will* do in the future, but what it is *already* doing now. AI will only make cyberterrorism much more effective and will also be used as a primary weapon of war on the digital stage. This war will be (and currently is) primarily about psychologically manipulating the enemy to self-sabotage in classic divide-and-conquer tactics. This is already being done on social media to fracture potential political solidarities to defend democratic freedoms.

Social media algorithms are a form of artificial intelligence and we now have several years of evidence of the destructive influence of algorithms on newsmedia, harms to mental health, spread of fake news, misinformation and disinformation, and even fueling sectarian violence. Algorithms have no ethical guidelines, their primary goals are simply to use clickbait and addictive or inflammatory content to maximize the time individuals spend looking at screens in order to sell advertising space to them. And that's the gentler aspect of it. The less nice part is exemplified by the activities of Cambridge Analytica and other for-profit propaganda businesses like Palantir. The goal of these businesses is to undermine integrity of elections and shift global politics to the far-right, supporting violent authoritarian and fascist ideologies. So far they have been very successful.

Any company using an algorithm should be held legally accountable for the harms done as a result of it spreading false, violent, or undemocratic content. Our democracy is in danger – it is absolutely unacceptable to allow corporate greed to triumph over what's left of our endangered democratic values. Children are killing themselves as a result of social media algorithms. Viral spread of COVID misinformation led to hundreds of thousands of additional infections and deaths. And the system is easily gamed by those who set up armies of bots or trolls for hire to create fake accounts and disseminate online content to artificially produce hype around a specific topic, thus spreading the propaganda even faster. On social media, fake news spreads much more quickly than legitimate journalism, and algorithms are largely to blame. Without defending fact-based journalism against this onslaught, our democracy is doomed. Now new forms of AI cannot just create fake accounts, but create dozens of fake online articles per hour, which can be used to make a fringe ideology or cult seem larger or more popular than it actually is. And people tend to follow what they believe to be more popular. Social and economic elites, especially on the far right, use AI to undermine the worldviews of their enemies, make them question their own realities, and make the public more vulnerable to manipulation by elite narratives. Our collective sanity is at stake and already suffering. Internet-related mental illness has skyrocketed in the last decade, especially since the rise of social media. This is a danger to human health, peace, economic stability, and social integrity.

In terms of economic instability, this is the other primary risk I want to touch on. The underclasses generally do not benefit from automation. Economic elites will use and are currently using AI to replace human labor. But unlike the introduction of other new technologies in past eras where jobs lost as a result of mechanization led to some fraction of those losses being gained in new tech-related fields, those who lose their jobs to AI may not

ever find jobs in other sectors. This is because a combination of AI and neoliberalism is very close to achieving the ultimate capitalist fantasy of zero-cost labor. In the past automation replaced low-paying jobs with machines, creating unemployment only in the lower classes. But now almost no job is safe from AI, not even in the professional class. Medical practitioners, lawyers, computer scientists, white collar jobs of all kinds may now be targeted for replacement as well. How does a human compete with a robot that can do a task quicker and more cost efficiently than a human being? What jobs are left to migrate too? Scarce low-wage customer service jobs perhaps with high competition – wages race to the bottom. All this occurs at the same time that neoliberalism guts government services and prevents un- and under-employed from accessing benefits they need to feed and shelter themselves. And who then has enough money to buy the stuff that corporations wish to sell, we may wonder? Overaccumulation sets in. Economic distress and civil unrest will grow, and AI's other side – that of psychological manipulation – will be used to take advantage of people's vulnerability and rage at an unjust system and redirect it towards xenophobia and fascism. We don't need to imagine how bad this will be – it's already happening all over the world, especially in the US. Unregulated use of digital manipulation tools is directly responsible for this extremely dangerous situation. We are reaching the edge of an economic and psycho-social cliff, and if the federal government does not address this crisis immediately with regulations, violent sectarian conflict will continue to get worse within the US. The risks cannot be overstated.

Those who are really studying the risks of AI do not fear it for its killer-robot potential (although that can't be ruled out either) but primarily for its use to drive mass society to insanity and violent conflict. Genocides have already been instigated by Facebook's algorithm (e.g. Rohingya genocide) and fascism is on the rise as a result of Youtube, Facebook, Tiktok, Twitter, etc. algorithms that favor inflammatory, racist, and conspiratorial content. AI is also being used to create artificial visual, video, and auditory content which can be easily weaponized to slander or blackmail internet users, or create fake news to sway political opinions. It is certain that these "deep fakes" will be used in the 2024 US presidential election, especially by the right wing against Biden (the far right is far more sophisticated in its use of manipulative digital tools than liberals or the Left, e.g. Cambridge Analytica and its descendants).

We need to ask ourselves this: why do we want AI? Who is it made to benefit? And who, by its very nature, does it harm, even if unintentionally? Automation historically always benefits social and economic elites and harms the underclasses, and the use of AI is no different. The only difference with AI is that it excels at making our exploitation addictively entertaining, circumventing our capacities for critical analysis of how it is degrading our abilities to meet our material needs. It is a weapon so expertly designed as to make our self-annihilation seem fun.

It is clear to me that the public should not have open access to these new AI tools without strict regulation. Military and police use should also be prohibited because it just exacerbates American authoritarian tendencies. Use of AI for surveillance capitalism, police surveillance, anticipatory policing, and facial recognition may be the downfall of privacy as we know it, and privacy must be a core protected right in any functional democracy.

If AI is used by individuals or corporations or governments, it must only utilize digital context from the internet with explicit permission of the owner, for example, of an artist who made a painting, or a photo of a real person. Use or recombination of digital content of a person or their creating without explicit consent must be illegal and strictly prohibited. AI's use for falsifying evidence or manipulating images or video or voice without a person's consent or without explicitly stating that the content is AI-generated must be prosecuted to the highest extent of the law. Human welfare and economic justice must become top priorities of the US government over corporate greed.

Lastly, AI has enormous environmental and climate impacts that are not acknowledged due to the immense amount of electricity, fossil fuels, and precious metals it relies on.